
Common Data Set 2025-2026

Welcome to the 2025-2026 Common Data Set collection!

The **Common Data Set (CDS)** initiative is a collaborative effort among data providers in the higher education publishers as represented by the **College Board**, **Peterson's**, and **U.S. News & World Report**. The collaboration is to improve the quality and accuracy of information provided to all involved in higher education, as well as to reduce the reporting burden on data providers.

The CDS is a set of standards and definitions of data items rather than a survey instrument or a database. Each of the higher education surveys conducted by the participating publishers includes both CDS items as well as unique items proprietary to each publisher. Consequently, the publishers' surveys include a mix of items from the CDS.

Those who report data for their colleges are urged to abide by the definitions and the coding for the CDS items. They are also urged to use the answers to CDS items when responding to the survey questions by distributing photocopies of their answers, posting them on their websites, or by other means.

This Excel template is designed for CSV export. On each section tab, responses are stored in a specific column. When exporting, verify that your entries appear correctly on the **Answer Sheet**. The Answer Sheet is available in the **U.S. News fillable PDF** and to the **Word** version. Please confirm with the receiving organization that they can accept the format of your responses. For more information about the Common Data Set (CDS) initiative, visit cds.collegeboard.org.

Please contact the **College Board College Survey** team at collegesurvey@collegeboard.org about this Excel template.

*Note: At the time of publication, not all questions on the **Excel** template can be matched to a single equivalent field in the **U.S. News fillable PDF** and in the **Word** template. The matching cells for these questions are in light red on the Answer Sheet. Please review and map these responses, and mapping before submitting a CSV to another organization.

*Note: As of publication, some questions in the **Word** template do not map directly—or require a single equivalent field in the **U.S. News fillable PDF** and in the **Excel** template. An example are category options such as "Very Important, Important, Considered, Not Considered". The responses may appear as duplicates (light red on the Answer Sheet) or a single category is listed as (c7_state_residency_very_important). Please review and verify all questions, responses, and mapping before exporting to CSV or submitting to another organization.

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